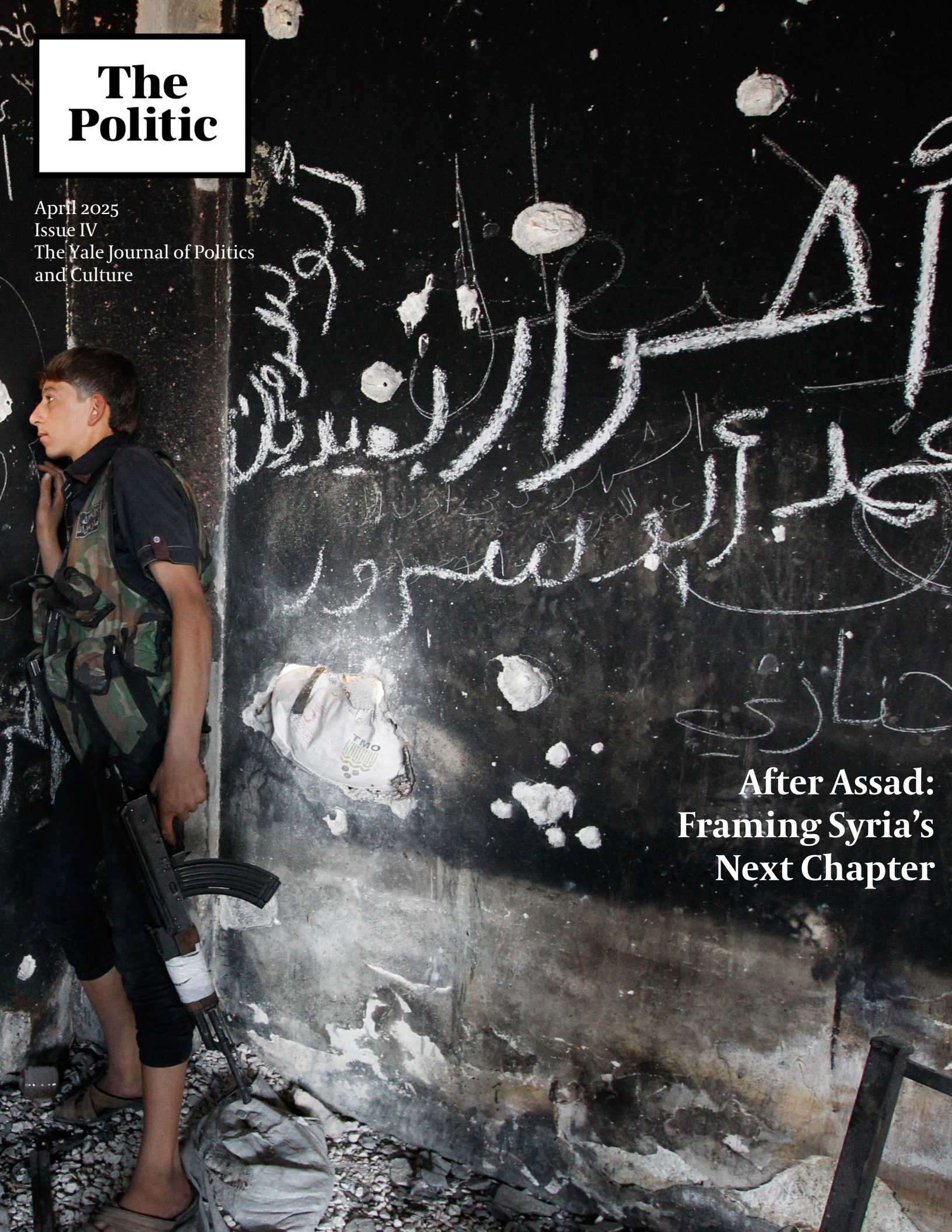
The Politic

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After Assad: Framing Syria's Next Chapter

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Dear readers,

We are so excited to share the first issue from the 2025–2026 Managing Board.

This edition explores the forces shaping our world today–from national politics and global unrest to the cultural shifts transforming everyday life.

Opening with a timely piece on Meta's quiet retreat from fact-checking, Lucy Dreier warns of the dangers it poses in today's fragile information landscape. In her piece on the fast fashion crisis, Natalia Armas Perez reveals how artificial intelligence, policy shifts, and local activism are transforming what we wear and how we think about it.

Our cover story by Sheena Bakare, paired with Muzaffar Salman's haunting photography, captures the fall of Assad and one man's journey through revolution, exile, and fragile hope for Syria's future. Conor Webb charts American Christianity's reckoning, as old institutions fade and new, often conflicting, movements emerge.

Aubrie Williams unpacks the reading wars, asking a critical question: what good is decoding if students cannot understand what they read? Kiran Yeh looks inward at Yale, where disaffiliated social groups are reimagining tradition with a spirit of autonomy, equity, and experimentation.

Finally, Rory Schoenberger's photojournalism explores the surreal coexistence of sacred ritual and mass consumerism in Vatican City, asking what it means for a space to remain holy in an age of key chains and crowds.

As a new Board, we wanted our first issue to reflect the values at the heart of The Politic: rigor, empathy, and curiosity. In these pages, we have worked to look beyond the headlines and tell stories that matter in the way they deserve to be told. This issue is a testament to the incredible work of our writers, editors, and designers. We hope you enjoy reading it as much as we loved putting it together.

Warmly,
The 2025–2026 Managing Board

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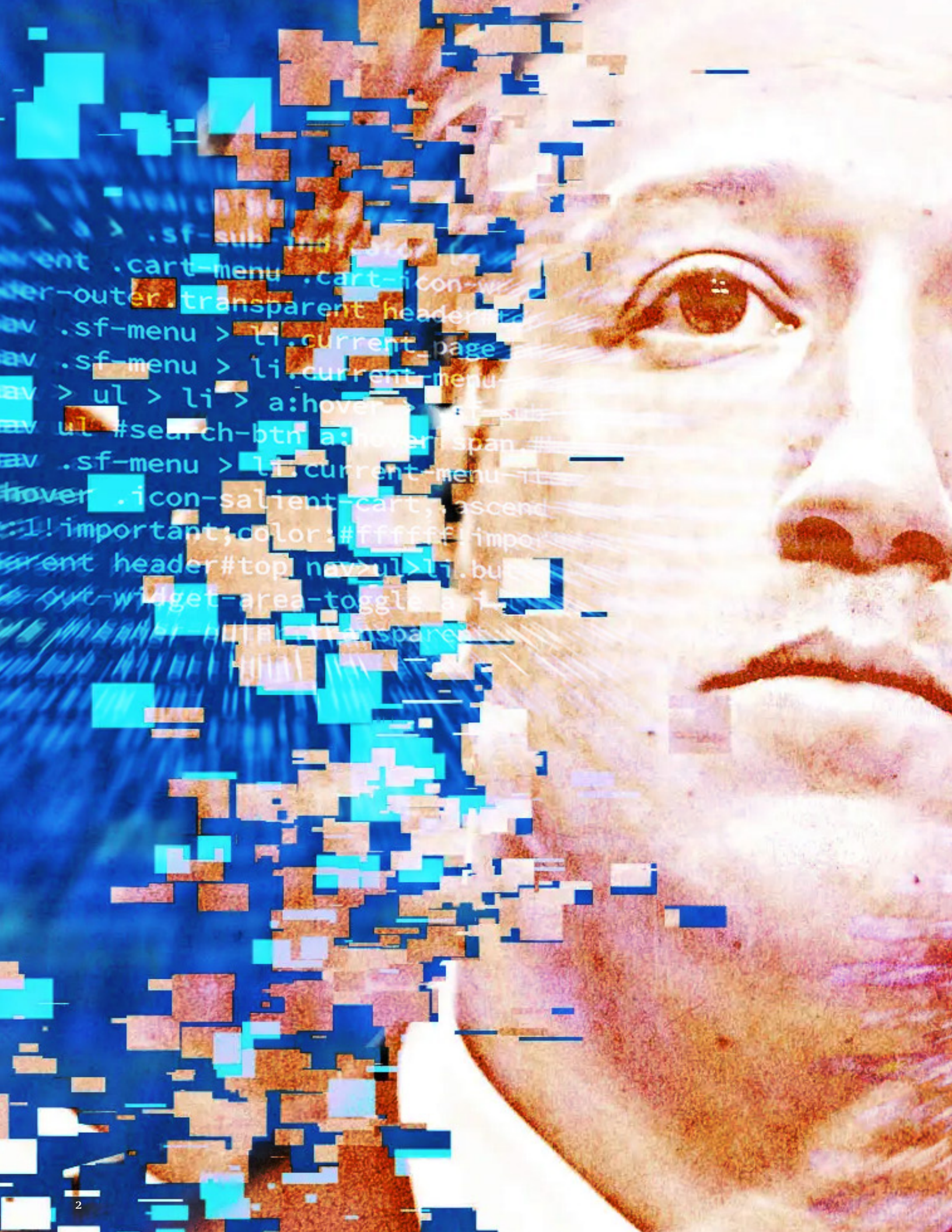
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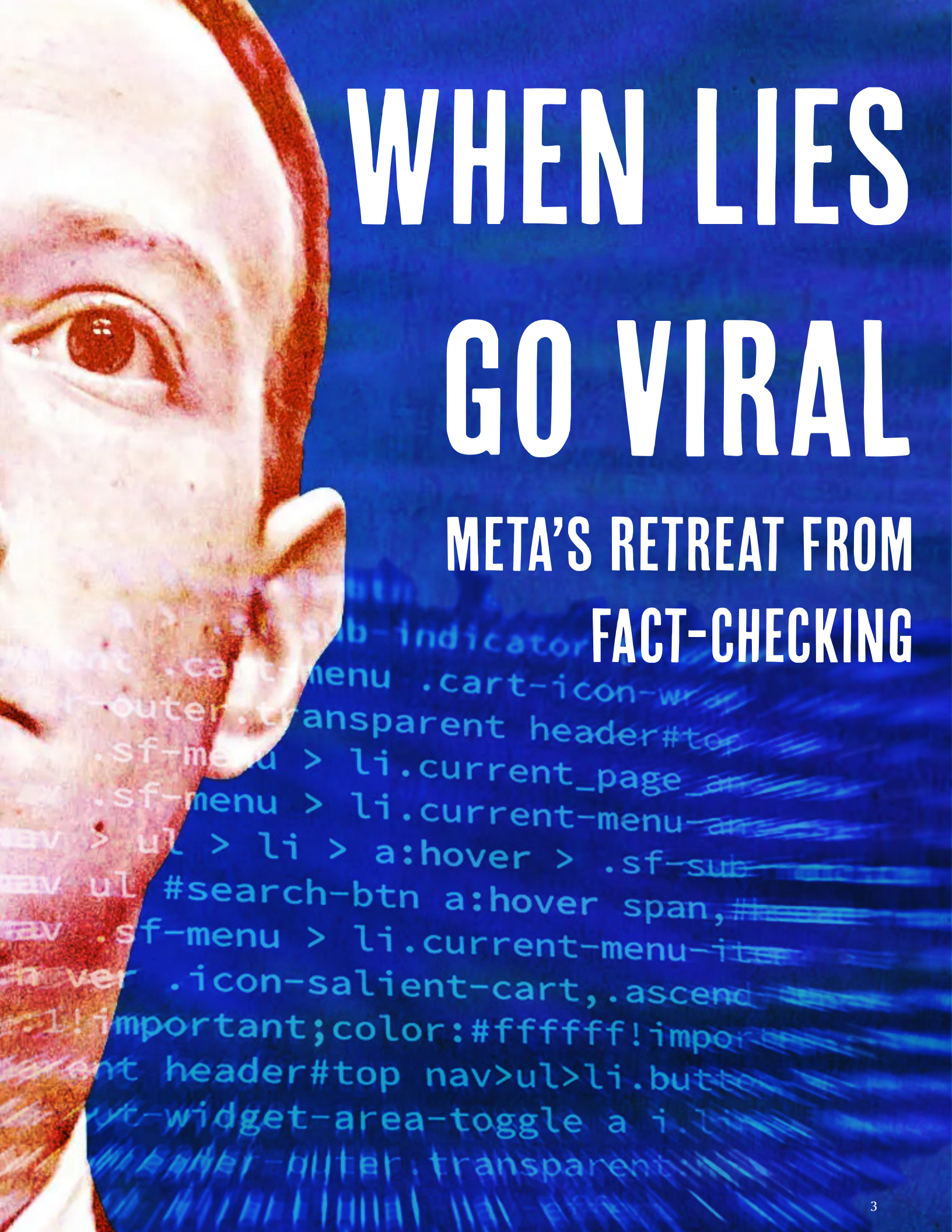
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WHEN LIES
GO VIRAL
META'S RETREAT FROM
FACT-CHECKING

BY LUCY DREIER

In 2012, Meta's algorithm pushed hate speech that fueled the massacre of the Rohingya people in Myanmar. This content, including a widely shared video from prominent anti-Rohingya figure U Wirathu, inflamed discrimination and animosity against the already marginalized group. Five years later, Burmese security forces launched an ethnic cleansing campaign, killing 6,700 Rohingya people and forcing 850,000 inhabitants to flee the war-torn country. Some say the genocide was only possible because of Facebook, now known as Meta.

The spread of misinformation on Meta also fanned the flames of the Capitol riots on January 6th, 2020, with the algorithm feeding posts that questioned the legitimacy of Joe Biden's victory. Additionally, this past July, violent anti-immigration protests inflicted by right-leaning groups that took advantage of Meta's platform to promote greater violence rippled across the United Kingdom.

The Myanmar genocide and the violence in the United States and the United Kingdom underscore the grave harm misinformation can cause and the immense and dangerous power that platforms like Meta wield. In 2016, Meta attempted to combat misinformation by adopting the non-partisan International Fact-Checking Network, a global coalition that promotes accuracy and transparency in journalism.

However, on January 7th, Meta announced an end to their partnership. The chief executive, Mark Zuckerberg, defended the decision, declaring, "It's time to get back to our roots around free expression on Facebook and Instagram." He continued, "Governments and legacy media have pushed to censor more and more… But the fact-checkers have just been too politically biased, and destroyed more trust than they've created, especially in the U.S."

Many Republicans have long argued that the fact-checking disproportionately suppressed right-leaning ideologies. Dr. Megan Duncan, an associate professor in the School of Communication at Virginia Tech, recalled, "For years, we heard conservatives, especially in Congress and the Senate, complain that they were being discriminated against by these fact checks. We don't have much evidence for that."

Critics stress that Meta's move signals a broader shift in social media philosophy—one that prioritizes user engagement over truth and appeases President Trump along with other conservatives. Dr. Duncan reflected, "It represents a change across social media platforms of their philosophy toward attracting a right-wing partisan audience."

Dr. Duncan also viewed Meta's shift as part of a growing trend among media platforms of valuing public consensus over expert analysis. She described it as the belief that "whatever people think is the truth is the truth, and that the average social media user en masse can decide better than experts."

In place of the Fact-Checking network, Meta has adopted Community Notes, a crowdsourced system requiring user consensus before a post can be flagged as false information. However, research indicates this system is highly susceptible to political bias.

Dr. Duncan's study found that when subjects were asked whether or not to contribute to a post, only those with the most polarizing opinions opted to weigh in. The study also found that people were not persuaded to change their partisan opinions about what they deemed the truth, even when their beliefs were challenged by evidence offered in the Community Notes.

Some studies report a 97% accuracy rate for Community Notes in COVID-related contexts, yet the system is far slower than traditional fact-checking, since it only flags misinformation once enough users agree. One report found that it took up to 70 hours for relevant notes to appear on a misinformation post about the Israel-Hamas conflict. Moreover, the report found that most notes are not even seen, and that most misinformation does not receive notes.

Dr. Duncan warned that bad actors can weaponize such systems: "We see so many people who view participating in crowdsourcing systems as a chance to play a game where they get to cheerlead for their own side," she explained. "More than rewarding their own side, people love punishing the opposing party."

"WHATEVER PEOPLE THINK IS THE TRUTH IS THE TRUTH, AND THAT THE AVERAGE SOCIAL MEDIA USER EN MASSE CAN DECIDE BETTER THAN EXPERTS."

Steven Brill, chief executive of NewsGuard—an organization that rates the reliability of news sources with the help of a team of journalists—was even more blunt in his criticism. Regarding Meta's decision, he expressed that, "It wasn't surprising, but it was also a non-event because their fact-checking program was just window dressing anyway. Of course, the thing they've replaced it with is even more absurd: Community Notes."

According to Brill, Meta's core business model has always revolved around maximizing engagement and profit, not ensuring the integrity of information. He believes that Meta's fact-checking program has never been reliable. Brill explained, "Their business model wasn't to catch inflammatory, false stuff. It was to get as many eyeballs as they could. And the way to do that is to publish as many hoaxes as you can."

For years, Russian actors launched disinformation campaigns promoting false claims about 5G technology causing brain cancer, which circulated digital spaces like Facebook, now known as Meta. Once the pandemic hit, they swapped out cancer for Covid. According to Brill, Facebook

would wait several days to fact-check, so the propaganda would have already gone viral and been seen by millions before eventually getting flagged. He concluded, "they have the same priorities they have had since they founded the company: they just want to make money." Meta profits from advertising, and the more inflammatory the posts, the higher the user engagement—and the more interactions with ads.

Meta's decision sends mixed signals about its stance on misinformation, with one perspective interpreting it as the platform prioritizing free speech over content censorship, while another perceiving it as a retreat from accountability. Assistant Secretary of Commerce for Communications and Information under the Biden Administration, Alan Davidson, expressed, in an interview with The Politic, "On some level, we are now seeing Meta's true colors. Mark Zuckerberg has made it clear that Meta does not want to take an active role in being accountable for the harmful content that appears on its network."

Experts like Dr. Duncan fear that Meta's decision will have dire consequences, especially in politically sensitive contests. Elections, public health crises, and moments of civil unrest have historically been breeding grounds for misinformation, with platforms like Meta playing a central role in its dissemination.

Dr. Duncan recalled past election-related falsehoods: "We've seen people attempt to persuade others that election day is a different day, or you don't have to go to the polls, or that you can vote by text." She continued, "all of these falsehoods could slowly instill distrust in the government and lead to people not participating in democracy."

Davidson echoed these concerns: "it's very frightening to think we will have few resources to stop the spread of very harmful misinformation during elections, public health crises, or in times of violence that we've seen around the world."

Meta's decision also triggers pressing questions about platform accountability. Social media companies in the United States are protected from liability under Section 230 of the Communications Decency Act—a provision that shields them from being held responsible for user-generated content. However, as Davidson notes, this legal framework may need to evolve if platforms continue to abdicate responsibility for the content they amplify. He explained, "There's going to be a very healthy conversation that should happen about whether those liability protections make sense if platforms are not holding up their end of the market."

He clarified, "I don't think anybody expected that Meta would be the arbiter of truth and police every piece of content on its platforms, but what it had committed to do was, in egregious cases, to slow the spread of really harmful misinformation."

Emerging technologies—particularly artificial intelligence—may play a role in combating misinformation, but AI is still far from a perfect solution. "AI will be a really powerful tool, but there's still a huge amount we have to learn about how AI will work in this space," Davidson warned. "There have been prominent examples of AI systems hallucinating on their own and making up facts." For example, one New York attorney representing a client in Mata v. Avianca used ChatGPT for his legal research and was found to have internal citations and quotes that did not exist. This raises concerns regarding AI's reliability, at least for now, given its inaccuracies.

Meta's retreat from fact-checking provokes questions about what this means for the broader information ecosystem and whether other platforms will follow suit. Brill observed, "X (formerly Twitter), encouraged Meta, and it basically gave everybody an excuse, first, to save money on the few fact-checkers that they have, but second, to have content that is as inflammatory as possible."

Davidson summarized, "companies have every right to choose to create the systems that they want, but part of the bargain that they've held out to their users is that these will be safe environments that you want to participate in. Increasingly, that's not going to be true."

Despite these bleak trends, Davidson hopes that Meta's move "will be a wake-up call for people that they need to be really mindful about their news diet." He suggested that users should look carefully and attentively at the source of their information.

In an age of the heightened spread of misinformation, digital literacy is more important than ever. "People need to get a lot more savvy about digital literacy. Oftentimes, when things sound a little too good to be true or too weird to be true, they often are." Davidson suggests, "I think we need a generational approach to helping people understand what's real and what's not."

For policymakers, he offered a final plea: "Don't give up on this issue. It's too important for our country."

"COMPANIES HAVE EVERY RIGHT TO CHOOSE TO CREATE THE SYSTEMS THAT THEY WANT, BUT PART OF THE BARGAIN THAT THEY'VE HELD OUT TO THEIR USERS IS THAT THESE WILL BE SAFE ENVIRONMENTS THAT YOU WANT TO PARTICIPATE IN. INCREASINGLY, THAT'S NOT GOING TO BE TRUE."

Does the Devil Wear *Fast Fashion?*

Environmental Costs and Cultural Push Back

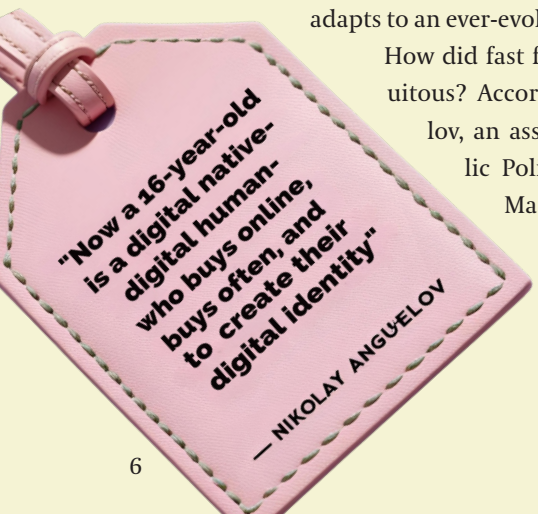
BY NATALIA ARMAS PEREZ

New trends, endless options, and prices that verge on the impossibly low. For those with the means, fashion trends drop fast and fade faster. Buy it, wear it, toss it—fickle as ever, onto the next obsession. Influencing identity formation and the environment at large, faux-couture's place in fashion is being tested by local resistance, public policy, and industry game changers.

***

Fast fashion is built on mass production, a process now increasingly driven by AI systems to sustain the rapid churn of trends. From fabricating denim micro skirts to bohemian-style sundresses, the machine adapts to an ever-evolving cultural landscape.

How did fast fashion become so ubiquitous? According to Nikolay Anguelov, an assistant professor of Public Policy at the University of Massachusetts, the industry's core demographic has shifted toward young consumers who drive demand. "Allowance money plays a powerful role in this cruel game of disposable fashion. The obsession is with novelty and affordability," he explained.



Joy Buchanan, an associate professor of Quantitative Analysis and Economics at Samford University, expanded on this idea: "Fast fashion is partly just a sign of a richer world. We can all have more of everything, including customized clothes." In a world where clothing is cheaper than ever, the desire to reinvent oneself through fashion isn't just encouraged—it's expected. "Now that T-shirts are so cheap to make, it's not surprising that people print them up for a single club event with little thought about the financial or environmental cost. Financially speaking, shirts are almost as disposable as plastic forks," said Buchanan.

Enabled by affluence, teenagers shop online constantly—not just for clothing, but for an ever-changing identity. "Now a 16-year-old is a digital native—a digital human who buys online, buys often, and buys to create their digital identity," Anguelov added. For many, clothing is more than just fabric—it's a fleeting statement, discarded as soon as the algorithm demands something new.

The psychology of fast fashion consumption, particularly among young consumers, ties deeply to the social validation of

trends. TikTok hauls and influencer endorsements create an illusion of accessibility—if everyone else wears the latest look, missing out entails personal failure. "There's a certain pressure to be seen in new outfits constantly, and fast fashion makes that financially possible," said Anguelov.

This rapid cycle of trend adoption and abandonment doesn't happen by chance—it's algorithmically engineered. AI-powered platforms study consumer behavior, tracking which styles gain traction and supplying this data to production lines. The result: an endless cycle of disposable fashion that feeds itself and is observed in the business models of the biggest fashion companies worldwide.

Shein, a global e-commerce platform emblematic of the fast fashion crisis, reportedly lists 6,000 new items daily. At a retail conference in January 2024, Peter Pernot-Day, head of global strategy and corporate affairs in North America and Europe, said that the company's adaptive model is a byproduct of machine-learning technologies predicting demand.

"Instead of having a design team at H&M or Zara stealing ideas, product managers now have big digital libraries," said Anguelov. Often operating with minimal oversight, these factories can produce thousands of styles overnight, ensuring that the latest micro-trends hit digital storefronts before they fade from relevance.

Buchanan further explained: "Brands don't have to guess what people will buy anymore. They use AI to scrape data from Instagram and TikTok to see what's trending, and within days, they can produce exactly what consumers want."

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While offering unprecedented affordability and speed, fast fashion conglomerates have an overlooked price tag: the environment. The average U.S. consumer discards 81.5 pounds of clothing each year—equivalent to over 2,150 pieces discarded every second in the U.S. alone. "People buy new clothing even though we have enough right now to clothe the next six generations," commented Esperance Han '28, an environmental studies major and member of Yale Sustainability.

The environmental toll doesn't stop at waste. The production processes behind fast fashion are resource-intensive, requiring vast amounts of water and energy, and often result in the release of toxic chemicals into ecosystems. A significant portion of clothing production relies on polyester, a synthetic fiber that contributes to microplastic pollution and takes hundreds of years to break down. Consuming over 70 barrels of oil in 2015, polyester production adds to habitat fragmentation and fossil fuel overconsumption.

These microplastics have been detected in water sources worldwide, entering the food chain and potentially affecting human health. "It makes sense. Fast fashion industries produce items in the cheapest way possible, which inherently means more dangerous chemicals, and that thin, cheap fabric is used in production," said Han.

While we know that synthetic clothing, particularly polyester, contributes to microplastic pollution, the long-term consequences remain unclear. "Are these particles relatively benign, processed by our bodies similarly to natural particles like sand and dirt, or do they pose more serious health risks that we've yet to uncover?" Buchanan questioned.

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Fast fashion has turned clothing into a battleground of fleeting trends, discarded waste, and environmental and health concerns. Yet, amid the chaos of fast fashion, a quiet resistance is building—strategic players are actively working to disrupt the system.

Witch Bitch Thrift, an alternative, LGBTQ-owned, women-run store in New Haven, is not just a place to shop, it's a community-driven hub. "We wanted to create a space where secondhand clothing is accessible to everyone, especially when it comes to size inclusion," said Virginia Semeghini, one of the founders.



The store's mission has expanded far beyond offering affordable and diverse clothing. "It has evolved. I've become painfully aware of the environmental impact of fast fashion, and now sustainability is at the forefront of everything we do," added Semeghini.

The shop's approach to combating the fashion industry's environmental toll includes a live buying process, where people can trade in their old clothes for cash or store credit. "We want to get clothes out of people's trunks and back into circulation," Virginia explained. This initiative fosters a barter system where customers can exchange unwanted items for new pieces, reducing waste and promoting a sustainable consumption cycle.

Even with fast fashion's presence in the shop, Semeghini stressed the importance of giving these items a second life. "The damage is done. We're better off keeping these things worn and out there than letting them end up in landfills."

Through the "Community Fund," Witch Bitch offers free store credit to those who may not have the means to shop secondhand otherwise. "If someone needs clothes—whether for gender affirmation,work, or just because—they can come in and get what they need," shared Semeghini.

At Witch Bitch Thrift, sustainability, inclusivity, and community aren't just buzzwords—they're the foundation of their approach, proving that shopping secondhand can be both empowering and essential in the fight against fast fashion.

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Efforts to curb fast fashion's impact have evolved to fill gaps in the industry. Rachel Kibbe, founder and CEO of Circular Services Group (CSG), zeroes in on sustainable consulting efforts and circularity. "I used to run a large-scale used clothing collection and resale business and saw firsthand how broken the system was. The U.S. lacks the infrastructure to process textile waste domestically, which means most of it gets exported—or worse, landfilled," she said. CSG's work focuses on bridging this gap: helping brands and the private sector comply with evolving sustainability regulations, implement circular business models, and develop practical solutions to textile waste.

Circularity, at its core, is about keeping materials in use for as long as possible—through reuse, repair, and recycling—rather than discarding them after a short lifecycle. But, without the right infrastructure, circularity remains an ideal rather than a reality. "I found myself sitting on over a million pounds of clothes with nowhere to send them. That moment solidified for me that without policy support and financial investment, circularity would never be viable. I launched Circular Services Group to help businesses navigate that landscape," said Kibbe.

CSG's work reaches every corner of the fashion industry microcosm, impacting policy, business practices, and sustainability efforts. In September of 2024, CSG consulted on SB 707 in California, the first textile Extended Producer Responsibility (EPR) bill in U.S. history, which requires brands to take responsibility for the circularity of their products. However, Kibbe's work also extends to the other side of the equation. "I work with law firms and investors on sustainable partnerships while helping brands navigate compliance with EPR laws. A key part of my work is creating the infrastructure to support both sides," she said.

***

While industry leaders like CSG push for circular solutions, policymakers are beginning to recognize the need to work alongside them by providing legislative support. In June 2024, the U.S. Congress took a step toward promoting sustainable fashion by establishing the Congressional Slow Fashion Caucus. This bipartisan group, led by Representatives Chellie Pingree (D-Maine), Marie Gluesenkamp Perez (D-Wash.), and Sydney Kamlager-Dove (D-Calif.), aims to tackle the environmental and social challenges posed by the fast fashion industry.

Kibbe consulted the Slow Fashion Caucus through CSG's policy coalition, American Circular Textiles (ACT), as she believes that "advocacy and messaging matter at the national level. With policymakers, we advocate for both regulations and financial mechanisms. Without financial support to accompany these regulations, businesses will struggle to adhere to large asks." Emphasizing the intersection of policy, researchers, and brands, Kibbe commented that "we build coalitions and highlight brand responsibility, but it all boils down to everyone playing their part for sufficient compliance."

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Partnering with brands such as L.L. Bean, thredUP, and Patagonia, the caucus works alongside the industry to influence fashion policy. Patagonia, an industry leader in the shift to recycled materials, uses 97% recycled polyester



and 91% recycled nylon by weight. "Many of our practices align with slow fashion conceptually: durability, classic designs, utility, quality over everything," said Gin Ando, an Executive of Communications at Patagonia.

Patagonia integrates these ideals into its business model, broadening the market's understanding of quality: "Although most people associate quality with durability, we use a system that accounts for things like utility—can it be used for more than one activity or sport? Fast fashion relies on the speed of production matching the velocity of trends—we operate on something close to the polar opposite of [the fast fashion] mentality," said Ando.

In a similar vein, effective messaging is crucial in shaping consumer perceptions and driving meaningful change, especially regarding sustainability. In 2024, Patagonia released The Shitthropocene, a short film exploring the psychological and biological signals that feed overconsumption down to the cellular level. Shown in stores, this 45-minute anthropological approach to consumerism reminds customers to be wary of impulse buys.

To expose the dangers of consumer culture and the thrill of aimless purchases, Patagonia sought to establish a bottom line of awareness. "Storytelling is by far the best way to convey this kind of information," said Ando. "Film is one of the most powerful ways for us to tell those stories."

Despite substantial progress, there's much more ground to cover. For example, the power of online influencers remains yet to be utilized for the collective benefit. "Take the anti-glitter campaign for example. It was all the rage until the Eras Tour influenced a spike in glitter sales and it all went down the drain," said Anguelov, who noted that individuals with large platforms can undermine sustainability efforts through mixed messaging. "It all starts digitally. How the messages are being communicated to you by whom, at what frequency, and with what promises. Influencers are powerful and we need to pool their efforts in the right direction," he said.



"Although most people associate quality with durability, we use a system that accounts for things like utility—can it be used for more than one activity or sport? Fast fashion relies on the speed of production matching the velocity of trends—we operate on something close to the polar opposite of [the fast fashion] mentality."

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At its core, leveraging community, platforms, and corporate responsibility is key to driving change. By aligning with policy, corporations can amplify their message and shift societal norms toward sustainability.

Fast fashion, in essence, is fleeting, fractured, and fundamentally a reaction to a capitalist society. Amid dynamic digital identities and a wealthier world, the environment is paying the price for rapid consumption.

However, every effort is contingent upon a shared vision of the future, with consultant groups and policymakers driving brand change from within. Only by reimagining fashion's foundation can we restore its true meaning and acknowledge the complexity of an industry where countless actors, from designers to consumers, shape trends, production, and waste.

Photos by Muzaffar Salman



After Assad: Framing Syria's Next Chapter

BY SHEENA BAKARE

On his 18th birthday, Muzaffar Salman received his first camera. Growing up in the ancient city of Homs, Syria, Salman was inspired by his father's photographs of Europe and took up photography as a hobby. This interest stayed with him through college and a two-year military service. Eventually, Salman refined his craft and began his career working for Al-Watan, a daily Arabic newspaper aligned with the Assad regime.

Despite years of photographing political subjects, Salman says his first real assignment began on March 25, 2011– the day the Arab Spring protests erupted in his new home of Damascus. It marked the beginning of the Syrian Revolution, a large-scale movement against the authoritarian rule of the Assad government, whose family has held power in Syria since 1971. Widespread corruption and a destabilizing economy drove public disillusionment and growing calls for change.

Inspired by the wave of pro-democracy demonstrations sweeping the Middle East, hundreds of thousands took to the streets. "I heard the protests in al-Amawi mosque so I rushed there immediately with my camera. It was new for me to capture moments that will make history," Salman told Reuters. From that moment on, he worked as a freelance photographer, documenting the uprising as it raged across the country.

Almost immediately, President Assad carried out deadly crackdowns in response to the uprisings. Over seven months of protest, nearly 3,000 people were killed. In an immediate public response, Assad blamed the uprisings on "conspirators," condemned the protests as a "foreign plot," and described those who were killed by the firing as a "sacrifice for national stability." The brutality drew international outrage, prompting the United States, European Union, and Arab League to call for Assad's resignation.

Journalists like Salman found themselves caught in the crossfire. Despite the danger, Salman's photography of political activists, artists, and intellectuals proved not only powerful, but essential in shedding light on the stark realities unfolding in Syria.

In 2012, Salman published a photo capturing the triumph of a protest led by 28 activists, and was imprisoned. After his release, the Syrian military appeared at his mother's doorstep, and demanded that Salman serve at a nearby base. As political protests spiraled into civil war, Salman made the decision to flee Damascus with his wife bringing only essentials—including his trusted camera. The couple made it to Beirut, Lebanon, just before Salman's name was added to a list of individuals banned from crossing the border.

Life in Beirut came with its own challenges. Salman's wife faced the looming threat of deportation because she lacked a passport. Meanwhile, as the conflict was intensifying across Syria, Salman found himself drawn back to document the unfolding events.

"My goal is not to provide statistics or data but to tell the human story—one deeply rooted in reality. I seek to reveal the truth of suffering and conflict, showing that they stem from the human soul itself rather than being mere unfortunate events, as they are often presented in the news,"







"For those of us abroad, everyone who could travel to Syria did so on the very first day."

"My goal is not to provide statistics or data but to tell the human story—one deeply rooted in reality. I seek to reveal the truth of suffering and conflict, showing that they stem from the human soul itself rather than being mere unfortunate events, as they are often presented in the news."

writes Salman.

Fueled by his philosophy, he took repeated trips from Turkey into war-torn Aleppo–the epicenter of Syria's brutal war, ravaged by relentless airstrikes, gunfire, and collapsing infrastructure. Leaving his wife behind, Salman ventured into the chaos to document war crimes, the resilience of civilians under siege, and the deepening humanitarian crisis.

In 2014, Salman's series of risky crossings came to an end. Just as the couple learned that Lebanese security forces were tracking his wife, they were offered political refugee status in France, and fled for the safety of Paris.

Now, Salman lives in the city of Rouen, continuing his art through street photography. His Instagram is filled with reflections of Syria. One photo of sailors lined along the mast of a great ship is captioned, "Something mysterious I felt…when I saw those sailors enter the city in this way, all I know is that exactly the same feeling came to me ten years ago when I was photographing people fighting for their freedom."

On December 8th 2024, thirteen years after Salman's imprisonment, President Assad boarded a plane to Moscow as opposition forces poured into the capital city. In a swift, two-week offensive, forces led by Hayat Tahrir al-Sham (HTS)—which held de facto control over much of north-western Syria—seized several major cities across the country. Damascus fell last and with it the rule of the 50 year hereditary regime.

"For those of us abroad, everyone who could travel to Syria did so on the very first day," Salman told the Politic, evidenced by the thousands of cars that jammed the main roads leading into the capital for days. "The truth is that I view the fall of the dictator Bashar al-Assad's regime positively," as do many, with over a million Syrians having returned home since.

Sam Heller, a fellow at Century International, leads policy research focused on the Middle East. He echoed the sentiments of Syrian refugees living in informal tented settlements in Lebanon. "The impression broadly was that… people were enthused about the fall [of Assad], and it alleviated some of the concerns that had previously kept them from returning…some of them had gone back to visit since December, some of them knew people who were still inside or who had gone back."

The sudden end of the regime sparked hope and relief, but the reality on the ground remains unchanged. "Not everyone can return," Salman said "as most people's homes have been destroyed—including mine." For many refugees Heller spoke to, "the country is still ruined [and]… for a lot of people, returning to a country in this condition seems unimaginable… there are no basic public services that they would need, including accessible healthcare or education for their children."

Beyond the physical devastation, Heller argued that the economic challenges facing the country pose a significant obstacle for the new government. Many of the foundational structures needed for recovery are either non-existent or severely weakened, on top of hyperinflation, debt, and heavy sanctions. Before the civil war, Syria's inflation rate was at 4%. The overall inflation rate in the months after the fall of Assad's regime was just under 50%. "[The new regime] does not have the re-





"Syrians, by nature, are hardworking, and most of them are well-educated. Millions of them now hold international expertise and prestigious Western degrees, making them fully capable of transforming Syria into a developed and thriving nation."







sources so far… they took over a country in a state that is bankrupt, [and] ruined economically. [There is] no seeming indication that anyone's going to step in and actually pay for all these military personnel. To run a government, obviously, there's some very basic things that you need, like money and infrastructure."

Despite these issues, Salman remained hopeful for Syria's economy. As he pointed out, Syria has the potential to be a rich country, given its strategically significant location and resources, specifically oil and natural gas resources.

The labor force holds untapped potential, as Salaman described, "Syrians, by nature, are hardworking, and most of them are well-educated. Millions of them now hold international expertise and prestigious Western degrees, making them fully capable of transforming Syria into a developed and thriving nation."

However, Heller noted that, "there is very little capacity in a lot of local markets to absorb new workers and to provide employment." The question remains how the diaspora of Syrian talent and expertise can be drawn back.

A critical step toward economic revival, according to Salman, centers on international sanctions relief. "The biggest challenge right now is lifting U.S. sanctions on Syria, particularly those imposed by the Caesar Act." The act, passed by Congress in 2019, put additional sanctions and restrictions on financial institutions and individuals in Syria. Lifting these barriers, said Salman, "is essential for Syria to rejoin the SWIFT banking system, allowing for reconstruction, infrastructure development, and foreign investment."

Internal and External Dynamics

Another critical challenge for the new government is establishing unified control over Syria's fragmented territory. According to Salman, "the new regime is linked to jihadist Islam, which does not reflect Syrian society." Multiple armed groups currently maintain de facto control over different regions, including Turkish-backed forces (SNA), Kurdish forces in the northeast, and the Syrian Democratic Forces (SDF) led by Mazloum Abdi.

On the possibility of these factions uniting to form a stable government, Heller is pessimistic. "I've followed the Syrian war professionally since 2013 and over that whole period, there's always some initiatives being cooked up for some sort of merger or consolidation of the opposition's various factions and then it almost always fails."

He pointed to HTS, SDF, and Islamic State of Iraq and Syria (ISIS), as the only groups that have established a monopoly of force in areas of their control. Everywhere else, "armed factions have a very specific local character, centered around a town, or a key personality, and have single funding streams. The act of actually pulling these factions together has never been recorded."

Adding to the complexity, Syrians are not the only ones shaping their country's political future, as regional and global powers continue to vie for influence and advance their own agendas. The issue of external influence is uniquely contingent on the security interests of Syria's neighbors. As Jonathan Wyrtzen, a professor of sociology and history at Yale explained, "In relation to other countries that had uprisings in 2011 and went into various violent conflicts and different sorts of reform, revolt, revolution, Syria had a higher degree of external intervention because it's in the middle of everything."

To the north, Turkey looks to quell the threat of Kurdish forces, hoping to establish a buffer zone in Syria. This interest further complicates how the new regime will go about bringing factions together. "It's questionable what Turkey's line is," said Wyrtzen "and how much flexibility President Al-Sharaa would have in integrating the Kurds and the SDF, because of Turkey's interest there."

To the south, Israel is advancing interests as well. The Israeli Prime Minister Netanyahu has called for a "complete demilitarization" of several provinces in southern Syria. Israeli military forces have indefinitely occupied southern Syrian territory and have launched missile attacks deeper into Syria, destroying military assets.

International policy towards Syria, such as lifting sanctions, will instead "depend on the behavior of the new leadership—not only in terms of transparency, openness, and the rule of law but also in their political acumen in

forging alliances that create a balance in one of the most complex geopolitical battlegrounds, where global powers are competing for influence," says Salman.

Despite these pressures, "I do not believe there is any real [territorial] threat of division," said Salman. He claimed that "both regional and global interests are aligned in preventing chaos that could jeopardize these powers' strategic interest."

In Turkey's case, for example, divisions could result in the creation of an independent Kurdish state, which would have serious regional repercussions, and could incite an independence movement in Kurdish regions elsewhere. "The main regional powers have no interest in seeing Syria split…[as] this would mean a complete redrawing of the Middle East map and, with it, the balance of international power," Salman stated.

Wyrtzen made the case, however, that the removal of sanctions and economic relief from the international community is predicated on something deeper. "Usually, [aid and sanctions] are used to make a Syrian subservient," he explained, "or to subjugate basically a weaker state… in the service of [almost] Western imperial power."

External intervention has long complicated Syria's path to power consolidation. Wyrtzen pointed to Syria's last major constitutional moment in the aftermath of World War I, when Arab and British forces liberated Damascus. After Faisal I was declared king, he established a provisional government to create an independent Arab state. The Arab Congress in Damascus drew delegates from across the region, including modern-day southern Turkey, Jordan, and Israel-Palestine. During the Congress, members "[came] up with…some kind of a constitution, but that summer, the French sent an army over that just violently quashed it and ousted Faisal," Wyrtzen explained.





A New Constitution

President al-Shaarah has signed a five-year constitutional declaration, rooted in Islamic law promising "freedom of opinion, expression, information, publication and press." It has been praised in part for its protection of individual rights, women, and minorities. However, critics are skeptical. "There are also clauses that seem like they could pretty easily be used to subvert and weaken those rights, and it concentrates a really substantial amount of power in the Executive and the President" said Heller. "Other separate





“I would certainly be documenting what is happening, even though it would not be easy. But then again, it never has been.”

“In general, my friends and siblings in Syria are cautiously optimistic,” said Salman. “On one hand, they feel a sense of relief. On the other hand, the future remains uncertain.” For now, Salman continues to capture life in Rouen—the trees in nearby parks, water rushing in small streams under bridges—through the grayscale lens of a refugee far from home.

His own return is complicated, citing massacres of Alwaites and religious extremists as one of many reasons holding him back. In his view, amidst continued instability, to return to Syria and give up his legal status in France would be “reckless.”

In the wake of loss and devastation in Syria, beats the heart of hope. Hope cannot answer all the hard questions, but it can light the way forward. Salman’s life and work defines what it means to carry that spirit. “If I were in Syria now,” he says “I would certainly be documenting what is happening, even though it would not be easy. But then again, it never has been.”

and coequal branches of government are largely, per the terms of this announcement, going to be nominated by the President himself. Such provisions certainly make this transitional arrangement ripe for autocratic consolidation.”

But Wyrtzen added a nuanced perspective on the constitutional moment: “One of the things that I think is important in a situation like this is to distinguish what a constitution is doing. Is it a document? Is it a guideline?” This question becomes particularly relevant as the Kurdish-led SDF and other groups have already declared their “complete rejection of the constitutional declaration submitted by the interim government.”

Wyrtzen, however, emphasized that: “In and of itself, [the constitution] isn’t reality, and it can’t create reality.” What Syria truly needs, according to Wyrtzen, “is a kind of Philadelphia constitutional convention moment where you can bring people together and hash out a power-sharing bargain.” However, given the intense external pressures facing the country, he acknowledges that “they don’t have the luxury of doing that.”

"A new command I give you: Love one another. As I have loved you, so you must love one another"
- John 13:34-35



THE CROSS AT A ~~CROSSROADS~~

CHRISTIANITY'S RECKONING IN MODERN AMERICA

BY CONOR WEBB

Collapse or Realignment?

Ryan Burge spent decades at the pulpit of a church that had been standing since 1868. By 2025, it was gone.

First Baptist Church of Mount Vernon, Illinois had faced no scandal or sudden crisis. Still, Burge blamed himself for his church's closure.

"I couldn't keep it going, and it feels like I let down all those people who had come before me, who devoted their time and energies and money to building that church. It feels like I failed them in some way," Burge said.

Burge expected First Baptist's decline. As an associate professor of political science at Eastern Illinois University, he studies trends in American religion for a living. As a pastor, he witnessed firsthand his Midwestern congregation's population aging as its pews grew emptier.

"Everything I saw in the pews was grey hair and a lot more funerals than weddings or baptisms or births," Burge observed.

The closing of Mainline Protestant churches like First Baptist reflects the decline of Christianity in the United States spanning several decades. As recently as the early 1990s, roughly 90 percent of U.S. adults identified as Christian. Today, that number is 63 percent. The number of religious unaffiliated Americans—which some scholars like Burge have dubbed the "nones"—have increased sixfold in that time.

Yet an astonishing trend has emerged since 2019: Christian religious affiliation and church attendance rates have stabilized. As younger generations begin to shape the future of American Christianity, one story emerging from the shifting landscape of faith is not just one of decline or stagnation but of realignment. While traditional institutions falter, new forms of faith communities are taking root, offering a redefined vision of what religious life can look like in America.

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The Fall of the Traditional American Church

Burge's church in Mount Vernon was merely a symptom of the disease. In Midwestern cities with dwindling populations, Mainline Protestantism is hollowing out.

The story is markedly similar in the deep American South. Though distinct in size, structure, and geography, the Southern Baptist Convention now faces its own form of institutional decline, as the influence of the megachurch pipeline begins to wane.

Zach Lambert felt the Evangelical megachurch pipeline pressure firsthand when he was selected by Jack Graham—megachurch pastor and member of President Donald Trump's Religious Advisory Council—to be his intern.

Lambert called his boss' church the "mecca of the culture and community of [Evangelicalism]."

"You're convinced there's no higher form of Evangelicalism than this church and these roles that you have. It's massive. It has 40,000 members. It's a massive campus with a full K-12 school. It has a Starbucks inside of it, a full restaurant, two bookstores," Lambert said.

Lambert had every reason to believe that this path would guarantee upward mobility through the evangelical ranks. "Being Jack's intern really was supposed to fast-track you into being a pastor over an area, then campus, then pastor over a megachurch."

But Lambert grew disillusioned by the traditional megachurch culture. The over-zealous advocates of the institution who missed the point of Jesus' teachings wore him down.

"People are stepping away because the Christians that they encounter are so unlike the Christ they read about

in Scripture. The pastors they encounter are preaching one thing and then doing another thing. The systems and structure they encounter within church settings do not yield good fruit—love, joy, peace, patience, kindness—that Scripture says are the fruit of God's spirit. They see a toxic version of that, and so I think eventually they step away," Lambert said.

The doctrinal hypocrisy frustrated Lambert so deeply that he ultimately decided to step away and start his own church over a bed of mozzarella sticks, sliders, and chicken tenders.

"I remember a final conversation with my wife sitting at a Chili's, eating a Triple Dipper and eating my feelings, and she said, 'Can you really keep doing nothing?' I just said no. And so I stepped away," Lambert concluded.

Lambert is not the only member who has left the traditional Evangelical institutions and looked elsewhere. Nascent factions, like his, have eaten up the once-booming institution that defined the group.

Burge disagreed that doctrinal hypocrisy has caused the mass exodus from Christianity. "It's actually much simpler than that." Perhaps people throw out theological disputes as a post hoc justification for their abandonment of church, but Burge thinks that it is unlikely those disputes caused many to exit.

"It's logistical. 'I moved,' or 'I got married,' or 'I got a new job,' or 'we had kids,' or 'other priorities took up my time.' Most people leave religion and stop attending church not because they have a theological or political dispute with the congregation, but because of real practical stuff," Burge emphasized.

Further, the bulk of those who leave traditional Christian institutions do not leave suddenly or loudly. Burge says that they "slowly slip away over time. They go from being weekly [church attendees] to twice a month and then once a month, and then six times a year, and then they're gone."

"When we ask [newly unaffiliated Christians] about why they leave, they kind of pick the easiest thing to say—things like, 'Oh, the hypocrisy of people in the church is why.' There's always been hypocrisy by people who call themselves followers of Jesus. I mean, that's from literally the beginning."

In contrast, Burge continued, "It's [harder] to say, 'I don't really know, man. I just didn't get a whole lot out of it, and I got lazy, and it was easier not going than it was going, and so I stopped going.'"

Dr. Matthew Taylor, the senior Christian scholar at the Institute for Islamic, Christian, and Jewish Studies, thinks much more broadly about why institutional Christianity has declined.

"There's kind of an open marketplace where new actors are coming on the stage: new movements are coming on the stage, and attracting young people. There's a lot of flux in that system. After the Second Great Awakening, it's the Baptists and the Methodists who've gotten old. Now, it's the conventional Evangelicals who atrophied," Taylor acknowledged.

Those "conventional Evangelicals" constitute the Southern Baptist Convention that Lambert left in addition to thousands of fellow congregants.

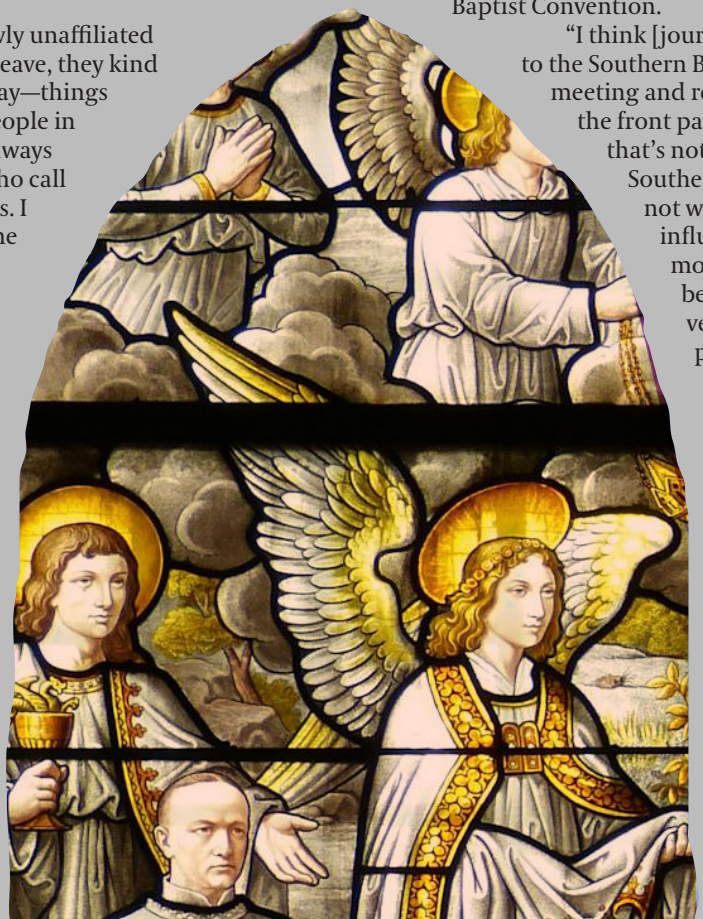
"The Southern Baptist Church is the largest Protestant denomination in the world with pillars of organizations or leaders that everyone looks up to. My grandparents were early founding members of a Southern Baptist megachurch in Austin. And one of the places that they always looked up to was the president of the Southern Baptist Convention and the handful of leaders and pastors who were very influential in the movement," Lambert said.

But the Southern Baptist Convention that Lambert's grandparents extolled is not as ordered as it once was. As people leave, either disaffiliating with Christianity or entering independent non-denominational sects, Evangelical factionalism has increased.

Burge said that "the Southern Baptist Convention is not top-down anymore. Evangelicalism has factions or pockets. You've got your Franklin Graham, Billy Graham's son, and he's an old school, traditional Evangelical, but then you've got Paula White, who Donald Trump loves, but mainstream Evangelicals do not like her at all because, first off, she can't be a pastor because she's a woman and she's been divorced and she speaks in tongues and she preaches the prosperity gospel."

Because of the factionalism that has characterized Southern Baptism over the past several years, Burge wishes journalists focused less on the actions of the Southern Baptist Convention.

"I think [journalists] need to stop going to the Southern Baptist Convention's annual meeting and reporting on what they do on the front page of The New York Times—that's not helpful because, again, the Southern Baptist Convention is not what it used to be in terms of influence inside the Evangelical movement. It's easy to cover because it's a big, fancy convention, and you can get press passes. But the harder stories are the disorganized, real Evangelical religion that's cropping out."



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What's Growing as

Old Churches Die?



"Therefore let us stop passing judgment on one another. Instead, make up your mind not to put any stumbling block or obstacle in the way of a brother or sister."- Romans 14:13-15

Churches like First Baptist in the Midwest are shutting their doors. The Southern Baptist Church's influence is fading. Yet the data is clear that Christian religious affiliation has been stable for over half a decade. In other words, some movements are rising from the ashes of the traditional American church.

One of those budding movements is the New Apostolic Reformation, or NAR—a right-wing Christian supremacist group Burge associated with Paula White, the inaugural leader of the White House Faith Office under the second Trump administration.

The NAR is one network of leaders within a broader independent charismatic movement that has skyrocketed in popularity. Leaders of the NAR dub their great revival the "Third Great Awakening." Independent charismatic Christians believe in the direct experience of the Holy Spirit, including practices like speaking in tongues, healing, and prophecy. In 1970, there were about 44 million independent charismatic followers in the world. In 2020, Gordon-Conwell Theological Seminary estimated that number to be 312 million.

"Peter Wagner, a seminary professor at Fuller Seminary who specialized in church growth, was one of the first to recognize this trend of people migrating and moving into these more non-denomination and charismatic spaces. He then got deeply involved with that trend and felt that he needed to help spur that on [in America] and join in," Taylor said.

Wagner began networking with independent charismatic leaders who identified as apostles or prophets facilitating the Third Great Awakening. Through the power of prophecy as evidenced in the Hebrew Bible, they hoped a billion people would convert to charismatic Christianity in the 21st century.

In 1999, Wagner retired from Fuller Seminary to begin building NAR networks. Taylor tracked the extraordinary growth of these networks in the course of only a decade.

"[Wagner] spent, basically from 1999 until retirement in 2010, building out massive networks. There were hundreds, sometimes thousands, of people joining in with these networks. And they were influential leaders—some of the most talented, charismatic pastors and leaders in the country who were hanging around with Wagner. Multiply that with the number of churches they had, and it had a larger impact."

The NAR initially branded itself as an effort to reform the church. Sometime along the way, Taylor said, its purpose radically changed.

"Suddenly, it became about: 'We need to conquer societies. We need to take dominion over societies. We need to lay claim to our Christian entitlement over the broader nations of the world.'"

In other words, the NAR radically shifted into a fight for Christian supremacy.

In 2008, Sarah Palin—the former Governor of Alaska and then-candidate for Vice President of the United States—was mentored by an NAR prophet. When Palin entered the political scene, the leaders of the NAR anticipated that they would "conquer the government mountain through Sarah Palin," Taylor said. The following years created the perfect theological storm for Donald Trump to enter the political arena.

"Of course, McCain and Palin lost. [The NAR] experienced the Obama years as a time of desolation—where the liberals are taking over our society, and God wants us to take it back. When Trump appeared on the stage in 2015, they were primed for someone like him, and they wound up having a lot of prophecies."

In 2016, Wagner endorsed Donald Trump—the only presidential candidate he ever endorsed. That choice institutionalized the religious fervor surrounding Trump that has persisted today. To the NAR, Trump was the God-sent emblem of an existential struggle for Christian dominance.

Witnessing this energy for Trump as a pastor in Texas, Lambert expects the NAR will grow.

"What I see [in Texas], honestly, is this right-wing Christian nationalist church on the backs of the NAR. Those churches are growing like crazy all over the country, and I think that'll continue to happen over the next few years, especially during Trump's time in office," Lambert said.

Lambert emphasizes that the NAR will not be the only movement that will grow—in fact, he's fighting to grow ostensibly the opposite of the NAR. After parting ways with the Southern Baptist hierarchy, he founded Restore Austin, an independent church that caters to those disillusioned by the Evangelical churches they once attended.

According to Lambert, many of his attendees tell



Photo credit: Ryan Burge

him, "'I'm not going to compromise on these values around justice and inclusion and equality for all people. I'm not going to go somewhere my queer friend can't go.' [Sometimes] they're queer and say, 'I'm not going to go somewhere that makes me hide that part of myself.' But they miss Jesus, and miss talking about the Bible, and miss a faith community, and didn't know you could have both of those things until they saw Restore."

> "People are looking for belonging. In a blase world in which everything is corporate and pre-packaged and approved by legal, people want authenticity. While I don't think that they're equal responses in some ways, they're so far different that they come back together and meet in the center, which is that they're a rejection of the suburban parish that is boring and unengaged," Cole stated.

While Lambert admits the NAR is growing rapidly as Trump has become enmeshed with contemporary American Evangelicalism, he thinks his church—and churches like his—will grow as well.

"I see [the NAR] continue to grow. I also see [progressive independent] churches like ours continuing to grow, ones that are committed to Jesus-centered justice, living out faith and values in the public square, and aren't afraid of speaking out boldly against things that are against the ways of Jesus," Lambert expressed.

Lambert has faced challenges as a counterbalance to the NAR and its related sects. He was accosted at an Austin dinner after voicing his opposition on social media to a law promulgated by Governor Greg Abbott (R-TX) that required that the parents of transgender children be reported to Child Protective Services.

"I walked into this dinner, and the first thing this guy says is, 'How dare you talk about our governor like that! Don't you read the Bible? We're supposed to respect the governing authorities.' He yelled at me in the lobby of this fancy dinner for pastors," Lambert said.

Other times, the frustrations of ideologically conservative pastors are quietly voiced.

Lambert shared, "I had an old pastor friend in the city who asked me to go to lunch—we hadn't seen each other in a while. He sat me down, we small-talk for a little bit, and then he said, 'Hey, there's this group of pastors I meet with, and a lot of us are frustrated by the things you teach about and what you post online, because our people see it and ask why we're not talking about racial justice or whatever. We talked about it, and they asked me to come have lunch with you and tell you to stop.'"

Some young people argue that the solution to this politicization is to embrace even more traditional, intense forms of faith. Skye Graham is from Hudson, Ohio, and attends Hillsdale College. She is in the process of converting to Eastern Orthodoxy, a small but growing sect that embraces fasting, rigid liturgical worship, and an ascetic approach to spiritual discipline.

"People are looking at these [divisions], and they're seeing no options for them. The appeal of something like the traditional Latin mass or Eastern Orthodoxy is that they are bigger and broader than whatever conflicts are going on in the American Protestant church," Graham said.

Taylor takes Graham's argument about the appeal of ancient Christian traditions more broadly. Institutional traditions feel new to people coming from Evangelical backgrounds.

"Even though Eastern Orthodoxy is arguably the most ancient Christian tradition, it feels fresh to people coming from Evangelicalism. That's actually been a trend: since the 1980s, you've had Evangelical Christians migrating out of Evangelicalism and populating this growing Orthodox community," Taylor asserted.

While Graham grew up with a mainline Protestant spiritual tradition, the Orthodox Church offered something different to her.

Graham said, "There wasn't any particular moment

[that led to my conversion]. I went to my first [Eastern Orthodox] liturgy, and it was different and unlike anything I'd ever experienced. I kept doing research, and the historical arguments for the Orthodox Church convinced me."

Being a part of the Orthodox Church is a lifestyle, and integrating into the Orthodox culture has been physically demanding for Graham.

"During Lent, we go [to church] every single day. Even people at my school—we live 40 minutes from the church—go every single day. We have a fasting calendar, where we fast for almost half the year. You're expected to go to coffee hour after church. [Orthodox Christianity] is expected to be your lifestyle, not just a building that you go to," Graham said.

Graham admits that these rituals are not attainable right away. Her priest told her that the rituals are about keeping expectations high as a follower of Jesus.

"He told me that they set a high bar, but if you don't feel like you can attain that right away, then maybe you just go without meat for 40 days [during Lent]," Graham added in comparison to fasting completely.

These three radically different approaches to Christianity—the NAR movement, justice-centered Evangelicalism, and Eastern Orthodoxy—are assembling as traditional American religious institutions disappear. What unifies them?

Father Casey Cole is a Franciscan friar and runs Breaking In The Habit, a blog and social media handle under which he's accumulated hundreds of thousands of followers on platforms like YouTube, TikTok, and Instagram. He reconciles the tension between the three traditions—partisanship versus nonpartisanship and ancient versus modern—by arguing that people have a hunger for faith no matter where they seek it.

"People are looking for belonging. In a blase world in which everything is corporate and pre-packaged and approved by legal, people want authenticity. While I don't think that they're equal responses in some ways, they're so far different that they come back together and meet in the center, which is that they're a rejection of the suburban parish that is boring and unengaged," Cole stated.

For those enveloped in the New Apostolic Reformation, people are angry about and frustrated by a neoliberal order and want to see something different so much that they will commit theologically to modern-day prophecy and apostolicism. For those seeking out a traditional Latin mass or an Eastern Orthodox liturgy, Cole said "they're tired of the blase of church and going through the motions and want to commit themselves to something."

"One thing I found in religious life that we've done terribly wrong in recent decades is trying to craft the message and saying, 'Oh, it's not that hard. Our life is a lot like yours.' We try to find connections [this way], but it's the opposite—people want something rigorous and difficult," Cole emphasized in reference to the rise of Eastern Orthodoxy. Cole "can connect it, in a weird way, to the movie Fight Club. It's responding to that late 90s corporate, everything's boring, everything's cookie cutter, [by saying] 'No, I want to do something significant.' I think that spirit is still alive."

"So when you, a mere human being, pass judgment on them and yet do the same things, do you think you will escape God's judgment?" - Romans 2:3

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Gen Z and the Digital Pulpit

Surveys show between 40 and 50 percent of Gen Z (born between 1997 and 2006) Americans identify as nonreligious. The religious disaffiliation of younger Americans has accelerated the decline since 1990. But Cole's argument that people will continue to look for belonging and meaning in life stands. The more complicated reality might be that Gen Z isn't fully abandoning religion but engaging with it differently through social media.

Gender matters in understanding Gen Z and faith: young men are both more religious than young women and are returning to church in larger numbers.

Burge thinks the online trend of "maxxing"—and the related young male lingo that comes with it—could help explain the rise of Gen Z male church attendance.

"Young men are 'maxxing,' right? The whole thing of [Gen Z] 'jaw-maxxing.' Those phrases have a religious component to it. The idea of staring at the chair in front of you on a plane for four hours with no food and no water and no entertainment is a form of prayer and meditation and skepticism, which is a very Christian concept," Burge said.

Social media's amplification of "male" traditional values accelerates the gender gap in religious affiliation. Beyond notorious social media phenomena and performative asceticism, social media content is not just about conversion. It can spread community.

Cole has found joy as a Catholic content creator in the digital world in the Internet's capacity to connect people in extraordinary conditions. Some of that is negative—it allows people to access fringe ideas—but it can create profound goodness, too.

"I think there's also a connection with religious groups [because of the Internet] where you can say, 'Hey, I'm in some podunk town, and there are no Catholics here. But I can watch Father Mike Schmitz or Father Casey Cole or Bishop Robert Barron, and I can say, 'Oh, I feel a part of something and have strong faith.' They can connect on chats or message boards or Zoom meetings, and it connects small minority groups that allow faith to flourish," Cole observed.

In Cole's experience, reception on social media depends on the platform.

"I've done parodies—they're just jokes, like 'cooking with St. Francis, here's how you put ashes in your food.' It was an infomercial that was very silly and stupid, and people on Facebook either didn't get that I wasn't serious or

got offended by it as if I was mocking St. Francis. On TikTok, people thought it was pretty funny," Cole said.

As a Franciscan friar, Cole's content aims to bring Catholics closer to their faith. According to Taylor, however, other content creators can weaponize social media to accelerate radical charismatic Christian movements.

"[Radical] movements have thrived online. They have a lot of influencers; they're technologically savvy, they're good at producing slick videos, and they're offering forms of religious belonging that are assertive and more misogynistic, playing into the Andrew Tate and Jordan Peterson 'young men need a purpose' kind of vibe," Taylor said.

That fringe concerns Cole. "The Internet connects people in a way that physical space can't. The negative of this is that it allows silos to exist. It allows people to connect across the world with fringe ideas—and so terrorist groups grow, and hate groups grow."

The amplification of fringe ideas gives anonymous viewers reason to target mainstream creators. In a recent video with a secular creator, Cole received thousands of negative hate comments toward him and his faith. "You kind of enter into the lion's den where you realize a lot of people don't have any basis in Scripture or religion. They see me as one of the sex abusers. They see me as a face of MAGA. Sometimes, they're so intertwined that Christianity [becomes] such a mess that that's all they can see."

Burge qualified Cole's belief that many on social media have no Scriptural grounding by saying that young people lack a grounding in Christianity that isn't Evangelical.

"[Conservative] Evangelical Christianity sucks up all the oxygen in the room. Young people don't realize there actually are religious Christian traditions that are cool with women in leadership and same-sex marriage and transgender people. Evangelicals are 60 percent of all Protestant Christians. I think they're like 90 percent of the discourse around Protestantism," Burge said.

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The Story We Tell About Faith: Today and Tomorrow

At its most theologically toxic, American Christianity substitutes spiritual identity for political identity. Graham has witnessed this substitution living in the Midwest.

"American Christianity in particular has been hyper-politicized. It was around the Trump era [many liberal churches] started adding rainbow flags to people's pins. On the other end, a lot of these conservative churches are literally flying American flags on Easter."

By extension, it has become easy to apply political language to traditional faith institutions. But Cole thinks it is wrong to apply a distinctly political lens to every aspect of faith.

"I think journalism can feed into this problem [of radical faith], which is applying an American political lens to the church. There's fighting in the church. The movie Conclave presented the sense of power-hungry people and conniving behind the scenes. I don't think that's as true as the media would like it to be; that's implanting on the church the only lens they can look through," Casey said.

Traditional religious institutions are declining as new, non-denominational Christian sects rise. In turn, Cole encourages journalists to "not pigeonhole or label or put people in those camps. I think it just self-perpetuates."

While traditional institutions are declining, Lambert cautions Americans from thinking that they are no longer influential. Some within the Southern Baptist church, for instance, have grown more radicalized by the institution in spite of others' disillusionment.

"You have a lot of pundits, pastors, politicians, who preach that 'hey, anybody who votes for a Democrat is going to hell.' Then, you sit with them later, and you ask: Do you really think this? They say, 'Ah, who knows.' But people are radicalized by statements like that, and they go back to their family and friends. They've been radicalized by people who don't even necessarily believe the things they're saying," Lambert admitted.

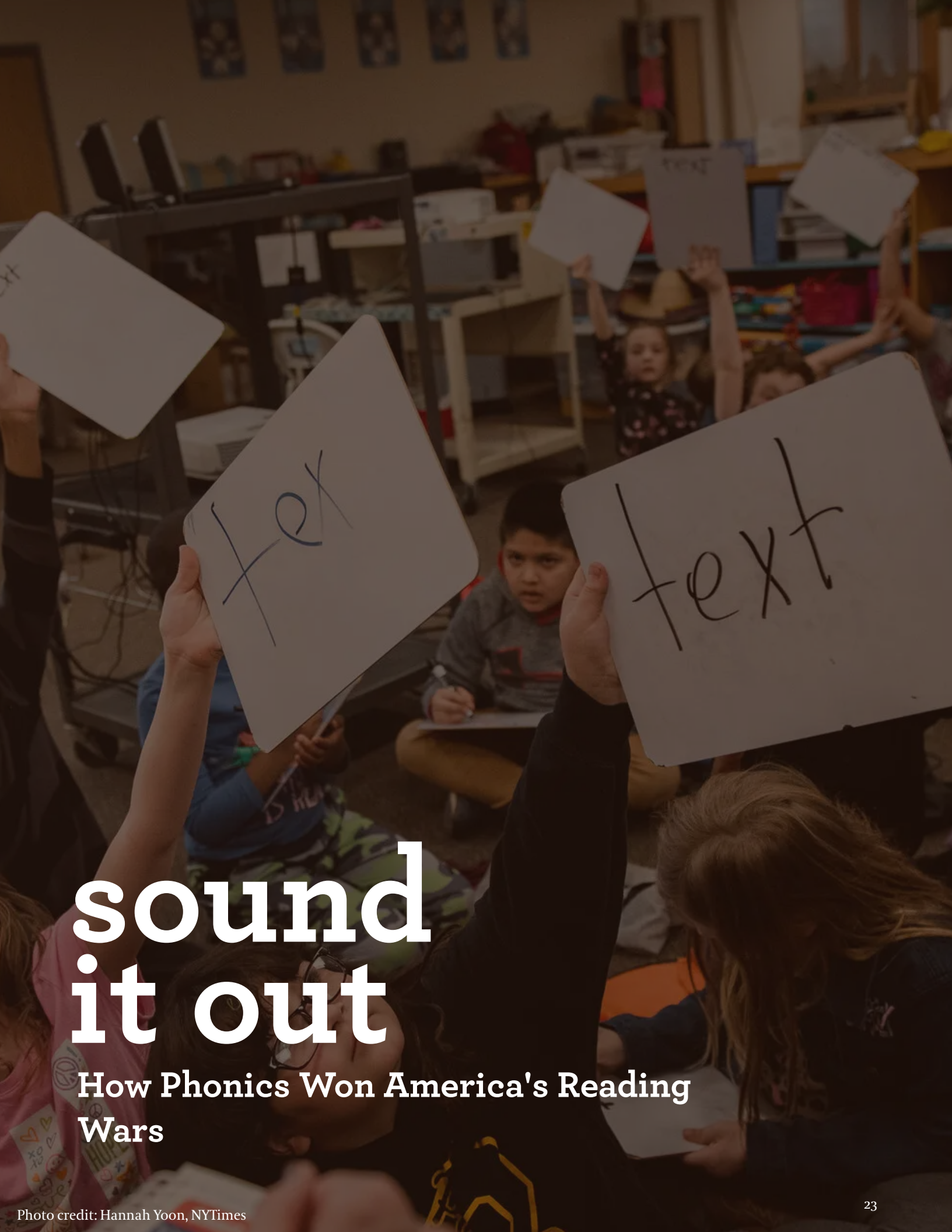
While the past five years have seen a stabilization of faith in America, the decline is far from over. The stabilization is temporary. Young people are still less religious than their parents and grandparents. As older generations age out, religious affiliation is expected to continue shrinking, with projections showing the U.S. Christian population could fall below 50 percent. If the decline is more aggressive, Christian affiliation could decline to a low of 35 percent.

That reality rattles Burge, not only mourning his own church but similar losses nationwide.

"We've sanitized the Christian aspect of history. We don't talk about the fact that Martin Luther King, Jr. was a pastor and that he used the black church network in the South to get his aims. The only thing people know [today] is the religious right. They don't understand that Christians, throughout all of history, have fought for human rights," Burge said.

"We've sanitized the Christian aspect of history. We don't talk about the fact that Martin Luther King, Jr. was a pastor and that he used the black church network in the South to get his aims. The only thing people know [today] is the religious right. They don't understand that Christians, throughout all of history, have fought for human rights."

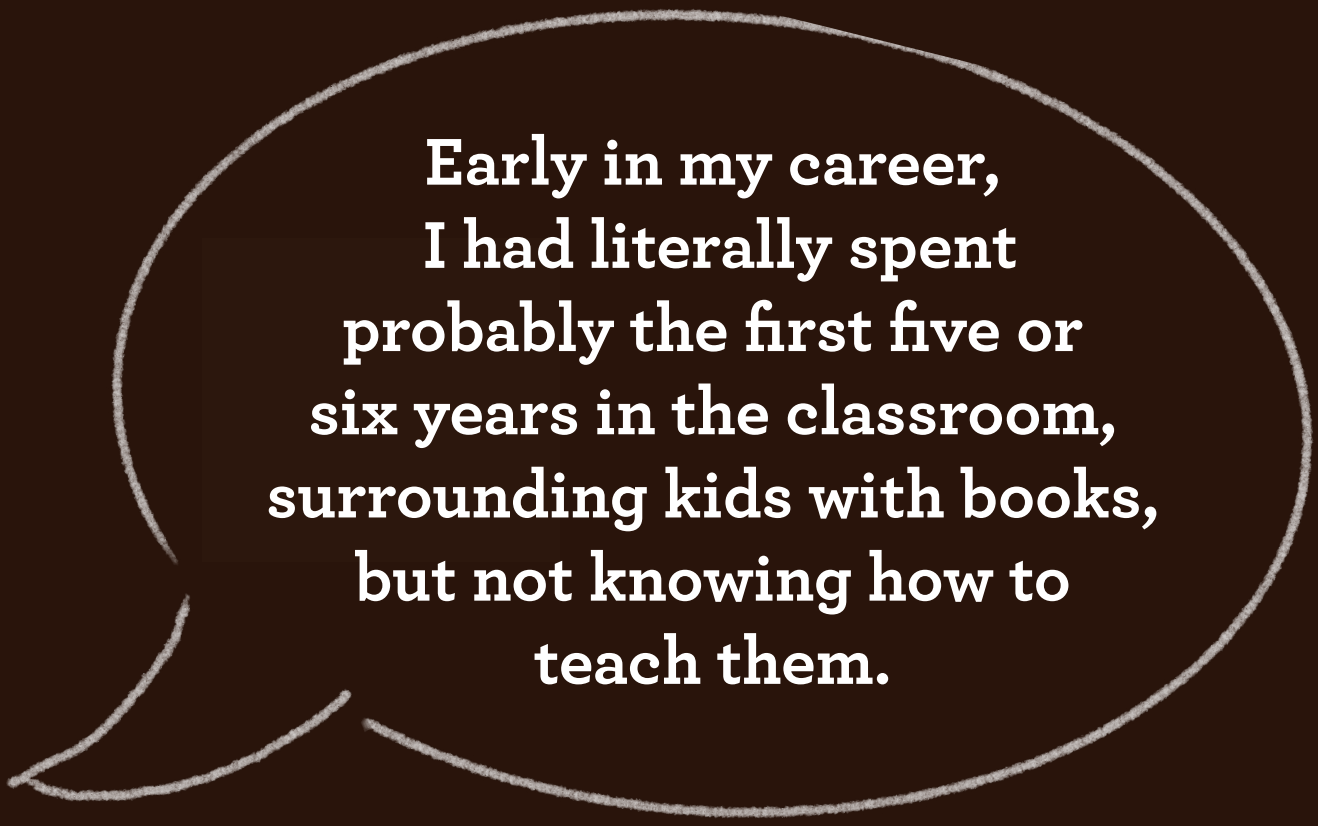
Christianity has anchored America's moral vision and collective identity. Whether it still can—or whether its legacy will be rewritten as institutions fade—is an open question.



sound it out

How Phonics Won America's Reading Wars

Photo credit: Hannah Yoon, NYTimes



BY AUBRIE WILLIAMS

Adrienne Gear's early days as a teacher brought an unforeseen challenge: despite her dedication, she was failing in her most critical responsibility—teaching her young students to read. "I love children's books and I brought them into the classroom. Some kids were able to read them," she explained, "but lots of kids couldn't because we weren't teaching them what we should.'"

The teaching method Gear had learned during her education degree– "Whole Language," a philosophy that emphasizes immersing children in books to encourage the natural development of reading skills—was failing to provide students with the direct instruction they needed. "The idea at the time," Gear recalled, "was that we're going to surround our kids with great books, and we're just going to cross our fingers that they figure it out."

A turning point came for Gear when a new movement took off in American classrooms. Coined as "Balanced Literacy," this framework hoped to maintain Whole Language's emphasis on comprehension, writing, and cultivating genuine engagement with books while adding direct and individualized instruction. "Early in my career, I had literally spent probably the first five or six years in the classroom, surrounding kids with books, but not knowing how to teach them. [Balanced Literacy] was groundbreaking for me," explained Gear.

Guided by the principles of Balanced Literacy, Gear introduced smaller reading groups, regular assessments, and designated levels based on each child's skills. The individualized part of instruction was most meaningful, "One thing that every teacher knows is that you are never going to have a class of children who are reading at the same level," Gear explained.

But the movement that Gear credits as revitalizing her teaching career is now widely seen as one of the education system's biggest missteps. Once embraced for its emphasis on cultivating a love of reading through exposure to rich texts, Balanced Literacy is now on the losing end of a centuries-long battle across American classrooms, commonly referred to as "The Reading Wars." Standing in opposition is phonics—the now-dominant approach—that teaches children to decode words by sounding out letters and syllables.

The Reading Wars have taken on many forms since they began in the 19th century, though most would agree that the debate is larger than just teaching methods. While phonics-based instruction has long existed as a method for teaching reading, it was often treated as one option among many—its adoption coming down to instructor preferences and district mandates. At the core of the pendulum swings between Whole Language and phonics is a power struggle concerning who gets to decide what children are taught in schools. The struggle plays out across research settings, state legislatures and classrooms.

Most of the criticism about Balanced Literacy revolves around one distinct aspect of the method: cueing. Cueing is a strategy often used to help beginning readers figure out unfamiliar words by guessing based on context, pictures, or sentence structure rather than through decoding the sounds of the word.

Gear offered a typical example of how it is used. In a book about farm animals, children might first see a picture of a horse alongside the sentence, "A horse is on the farm," followed by a page showing a pig with the matching sentence, "A pig is on the farm." The pattern and images guide students to rely on context rather than fully breaking down the words.

Gear explained, "If a child is reading that book, once they know the pattern, they can get through the book and it sounds like they're reading. But the problem is, if they saw the word horse in a different book with no picture, they would not be able to read it." This flaw in the balanced literacy system allowed many children to slip through the cracks. While they appeared to be reading, they actually



“It’s not like you have two different methodologies or forms of instruction that essentially get the same result, and you’re just picking one over the other,” he explained, “Not even close. Science of Reading blows Whole Language out of the water, by far.”

lacked a solid-foundation necessary for reading proficiency.

As concerns about the shortcomings of cueing began to surface among educators, parents, and policymakers, so too did a growing body of research—offering phonics as a more structured, scientific alternative. This collection of research is colloquially referred to as the “Science of Reading.” It implicitly casts doubt on methods outside of phonics’ bounds.

Recently, the APM podcast “Sold a Story,” which details how once popular reading curriculums conflicted with decades of research, has spurred a fresh wave of legislation and endorsement for phonics-based instruction. The podcast’s release, alongside growing grassroots movements advocating for children with dyslexia and concerns about post-pandemic declines in literacy have led 25 states to pass laws mandating “evidence-based” reading instruction.

Minnesota state senator, Zach Duckworth, was behind two such bills in his home state, which mandate phonics instruction and provide additional funding for such measures. His motivation was personal, “Before I was in the State Senate, I was a school board member. I’ve also got four little kids, and I’m somebody personally that, when I was in elementary school, got a little bit of extra help with reading.”

Duckworth, like many students, didn’t take naturally to reading, but credits his development to methodical phonics lessons. When Minnesota, like many other states, saw literacy rates decline in recent years, Duckworth took a closer look at reading instruction and was surprised by how far schools had moved away from that approach. “When I was a kid, I used to hear commercials for Hooked on Phonics. I can’t remember the last time I’ve seen or heard a commercial for them,” he explained.” Hooked on Phonics, a commercial reading program focused on letter recognition and audio-visuals, gained widespread popularity in the 1990s through its extensive advertising in television and radio.

Though it is too early to see the full effects of his legislation, Duckworth is optimistic. “When they receive the instruction,” he said, referring to new teacher training initiatives, “generally the feedback is pretty good. And many of them say they wish they would have received it much sooner—even when they were getting their teaching degree.”

In the long run, Duckworth has little doubt about the improvement that phonics-based instruction will bring. “It’s not like you have two different methodologies or forms of instruction that essentially get the same result, and you’re just picking one over the other,” he explained, “Not even close. Science of Reading blows Whole Language out of the water, by far.”

However, some experts remain skeptical of the promise that phonics-instruction will solve literacy problems in American schools, especially when it comes to proficiency among older students. “Nobody has a very good understanding or knowledge of how reading is taught in the United States,” explained Timothy Shanahan, professor at the University of Illinois at Chicago College of Education, “We don’t have any kind of ongoing monitoring of instructional practices in schools.”

Most of the tracking used to inform the movement is actually based on national reading scores, where observers see correlations between an increase in phonics-based reading programs and subsequent improvements in fourth-grade test scores. However, Shanahan explained that reporters and policymakers may be focusing too much on these specific measures. “They have the idea that if they get those third grade or fourth grade reading scores up, then the problem is solved,” he explained, “But if you look at the scores over the last 50 years, even when the third grade or fourth grade scores are up, the eighth grade scores stay flat.”

The long-term advantages of phonics are still up for debate, but the data for students with dyslexia and related learning difficulties is clear: they benefit significantly more from phonics

instruction. This group of students has become a focal point for educators and policymakers addressing the gaps left by Balanced Literacy.

Caryl Frankenberger, director of Frankenberger Associates Learning Solutions Center in Connecticut, works closely with these students, teaching the fundamental skills overlooked in less explicit methods of instruction.

Many students, she explained, enter school already struggling to blend sounds and grasp the alphabet. "When they go into first grade, if they don't receive something more structured, they really struggle to learn to read. They may or may not be dyslexic. Not all of them are," she said. Frankenberger added that with explicit instruction early on, many of these students could avoid reading difficulties later.

"I've worked with kids who go all the way through high school and get into college without actually being able to read well," Frankenberger explained, "And it's shocking when it happens, but I've seen students show up in college—bright kids, good students—but they struggle so badly with reading that it finally gets noticed. It happens more than people think." Frankenberger referred to this group of students as "instructional casualties," a phrase borrowed from neuroscientist Reid Lion.

Frankenberger added that the system itself is responsible for these issues, not individual teachers. "You have teachers who mean well but were never given the tools to actually help struggling readers. And then they're thrown into a classroom with 30 kids and expected to somehow individualize instruction for the five or six students who are falling behind."

Gear shares this concern, questioning whether a shift toward phonics can fully solve the challenge of reaching all students, particularly for those who grasp phonics early and require deeper, more challenging instruction to stay engaged. "Just how the balanced reading worked really well for 80% of the kids, but 20% weren't getting it, I feel like now we're replicating that. Phonics is being taught, and 80% of the kids are really responding to the orthographic mapping lessons, but 20% are bored out of their mind."

On a recent visit to a classroom, Gear's concerns came to light as she observed a younger teacher instructing through the phonics method. "She was doing an amazing phonics lesson that I just happened to be in the room watching," Gear explained, "But what she didn't notice, that I noticed right away, is three little boys at the back of the carpet, and they're rolling around on the carpet…and they're looking at each other and they're groaning because they know the short letter A or whatever sounds that she was teaching."

This disengagement from certain students reflected Gear's concern that such rudimentary phonics instruction is excluding certain students. It also points to a deeper concern of Gear's that the richer, meaningful side of reading is being lost to a more mechanistic approach. "What I worry about right now in the reading instruction that I'm seeing is so much time in a classroom is spent on the code that the comprehension is now on the back burner," Gear explained.

Like Shanhan, Gear agreed that comprehension should receive more focus in the larger conversation about how reading is taught. "I know that instruction in phonics is essential to a reading program, and I am never, ever arguing that what you're doing in those programs are not important." she explained, "But so is comprehension…because if we forget about it, we're going to have a generation of master decoders who don't understand what they're reading about."

Gear's concerns highlight a lingering issue in the Reading Wars that is yet to be resolved—while phonics has emerged as the dominant method for teaching young students, perhaps Balanced Literacy should not be dismissed entirely. The data may have clarified how students learn to recognize words, but the deeper question of how to impart meaning from those words remains uncertain.

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DISAFFILIATION AT YALE:
Community Beyond Greek Life



At Yale, four groups have severed ties with their national organizations, a move driven, in part, to rethink the rigid structures of Greek life rather than simply reproduce them.

Greek life does not dominate the social scene in New Haven; parties and mixers are just as likely to be hosted by secret societies, sports houses, acapella groups, or independent social clubs. Even within Greek life, only a fraction of members live in their houses, reinforcing the sense that their presence is more diffuse–quieter and less centralized.

Party culture is dispersed across loosely connected pockets on the outskirts of campus. On High Street, between Chapel and Crown, a row of Victorian Italianate and Queen Anne-style houses—boxy, unassuming—blends into the city's townhouses. Aside from the modest Corinthian columns at their entrances and the discreet lettering above 37 High Street, there is little to distinguish them as centers of fraternity life. This short stretch could be Yale's version of a "frat row," but its architecture offers few clues to its real social function.

Over the last hundred years, across the nation, Greek life has faced growing criticism, particularly for its racial exclusivity, often functioning as predominantly white institutions. Fraternities, in particular, have come under scrutiny for issues ranging from hazing, substance abuse, and destructive partying to discrimination and sexual assault. Sororities are often critiqued for fostering elitism and promoting unrealistic and toxic social standards.

Some disaffiliated groups have made efforts to remove the stereotypes that define the system. Others have hewed more closely to the customs they inherited. The rationales for disaffiliation vary—financial burdens tied to chapter houses, resistance to outdated rituals, and, in some cases, allegations of sexual misconduct or racism.

These groups are not staging a revolution, nor do they claim to be dismantling the social order that Greek life sustains. Many of its problematic aspects indeed persist. "It is a pretty toxic and exclusionary space. So far, it is quite selective," said an anonymous first-year student at Yale College, who is not in any social group. "But I think a lot of [other] organizations are."

However, by breaking from their national affiliations, they have gained something else: autonomy.

The Fence Club, originally a chapter of the Psi Upsilon fraternity—founded in 1839— went co-ed in 1972, only to be dismantled in 1979 due to financial difficulties. After disappearing from campus for nearly three decades, it returned without ties to its former fraternity. Once reputed as "the richest and most exclusive of Yale's fraternities" by The New York Times, its current reputation, as summed up by pledge Santiago Giraldo '28, is "pretty gay."

In 2016, LEO disaffiliated from Sigma Alpha Epsilon due to a mix of "issues of race, diversity, and inclusion," according to the Yale Daily News (YDN). The Executive Board declined to comment, but many interviewees described LEO as akin to a traditional fraternity, often likening it to Sigma Nu.

Edon, once a chapter of Sigma Phi Epsilon, formally disaffiliated in September 2020. According to the YDN, the decision to disaffiliate was due to financial concerns, ideological differences with the national organization, the sale of their house, and a desire for greater inclusivity. In its first year of disaffiliation, it extended its membership to women. Once a traditional fraternity, it has a reputation of being full of, "indie bitches," according to Elias Shaw-Rothberg '28.

Aeris was the last to disaffiliate in 2022 from Phi Beta Phi. The decision was driven by multiple concerns — including over $100,000 in debt owed to the national organization due to housing costs during the 2020–2021 school year, financial aid pressures, and the national chapter's disproportionate spending on political donations and lobbying compared to philanthropic efforts, according to "founding mother" Dorothea Robertson '25 and reporting by the YDN.

"Pi Phi had a reputation of bringing great energy to the parties they were invited to," said another "founding mother," Sofia Manriquez '25. "We've always kind of been this way, and now it's just being more intentional about opening up to the rest of campus."

These groups have taken what they want from Greek life—its rituals of belonging and camaraderie—while reworking what no longer fits. Of course, many rituals have remained the same.

But recruitment, lineages, pledging, partying, and initiation rites—once central to their Greek past—have been selectively reinterpreted and adapted to suit changing priorities. The result is something familiar yet distinct: a space where tradition is not merely inherited but continually reshaped.

Perhaps the most significant shift, however, happened at the very start: by breaking from traditional rush and recruitment, they have been able to introduce processes that national Greek organizations might wish to adopt but cannot under existing regulations.

At Edon, potential new members (PNMs) —or, as they call them, "fish" — meet for multiple meals over three weeks, each with different members of the group. After each meal, an Edon member connects the PNM with others in the organization, encouraging them to reach out. During Delibs—the process where Edon's board decides which PNMs to move forward with—a Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion (DEI) officer ensures that discussions remain intentional, particularly regarding race, background, and sexual orientation. Fence PNMs also grab meals, just much less. Pledge Jaeha Jang '28 had three meals.

Edon quickly broke from the mold of a traditional fraternity by becoming co-ed. In five years, much has changed—but five years is hardly enough to settle into permanence. The group is still refining itself and testing what works. "Within the club, we talk about Edon as a big experiment," said a Development, or Dev, Chair for Edon. The Dev Chair requested anonymity "for personal and professional reasons."

"One of the biggest things is during our weekly board meetings, we talk about [what] we need to improve." He said that as Yale's student body changes, Edon will learn how to adapt to make their processes fair.

The role of a Dev Chair—a position that traditionally resembles a pledgemaster, a role tied to someone who leads hazing—marks a meaningful departure from that legacy. In a traditional fraternity, hazing often involves grueling physical and mental challenges designed to forge "brotherhood." Pledges are typically at the mercy of all upperclassmen.

The Dev class, the equivalent of a pledge class, is given more autonomy to say 'no' to tasks, which differs from a traditional fraternity. "If anyone's uncomfortable with whatever we're doing… they can talk to us," said the Dev Chair. "No one's ever forced to drink [or] to do things that make them deeply uncomfortable."

The Dev class is divided into smaller Snapchat group chats, each led by a Dev Chair who serves as a point of contact. Every Sunday, the five Dev Chairs meet over brunch to refine the initiation process: deciding which tasks to keep, which to discard, and how best to pair members, often matching those who might not otherwise cross paths. They also consider which tasks each person might enjoy or engage with the most. These tasks usually include public embarrassment but are carefully thought out with a team-building purpose.

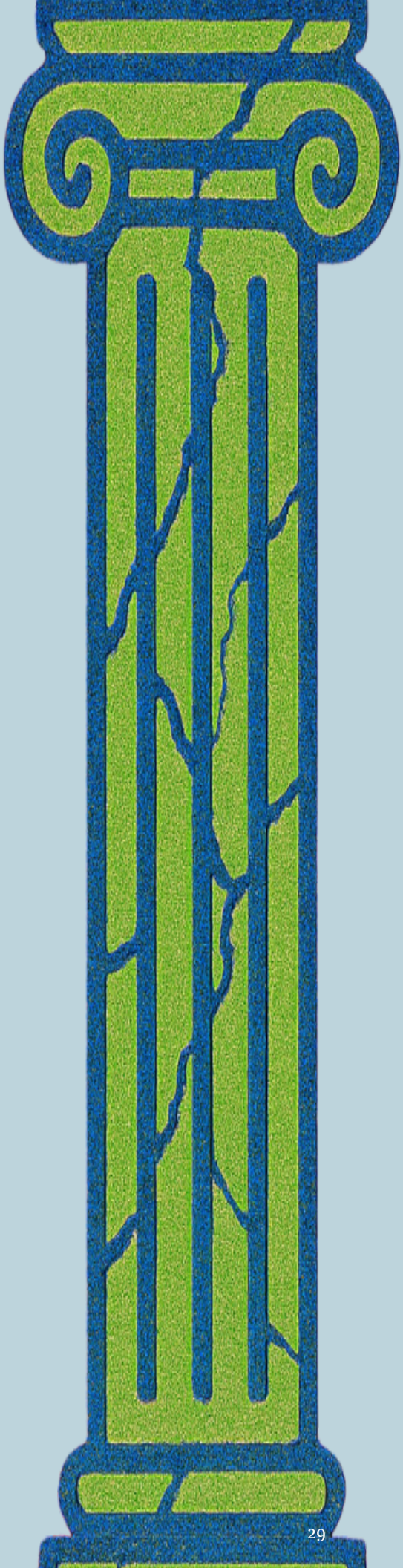
"The whole name for it is development and not pledging," said the Dev Chair. "The process isn't about pledging loyalty to the frat—it's about developing relationships within your class, meeting people, and forming actual bonds."

Not all traditions from the Sig Ep days are lost. Rose Buchdahl '28, who joined Edon this spring, has been sharing some of her Dev tasks in her family group chat—only to realize that many of them echo what her older brother, a Yale alum, experienced in SigEp. Building a table and early morning runs are some rituals that they have both endured.

But now that the group is co-ed, its members are acutely aware of how physical tasks affect men and women differently. Rather than abandon tradition, they are intent on adapting it—modifying the tasks so that they endure, but in a way that feels more equitable.

During the run, Buchdahl noticed there was no pressure to keep a certain pace; a walking group was available, and even the running group moved at a comfortable, reasonable speed. "I think the intention is always that this is supposed to be fun, community-building," she said. "They never want it to feel like I'm incapable of running at this pace [either because] I'm a woman or because I'm not in as good shape. I think they're trying to be inclusive, even in the ways that they're maintaining certain traditions from the old."

Similarly, Aeris has introduced a pledge process. This year, three "Pledge Moms" oversee the pro-



cess, their role mirroring that of Dev Chairs. The tasks themselves, Sofia Prieto Black '27, one of this year's Pledge Moms, described as "weird, silly tasks"—things like performing interpretive dances in Starr Library or participating in a group wolf howl in Commons. Since this is only their second year of disaffiliation, the process is still evolving. Last year, pledges filled out a Google Form ranking how difficult they wanted the process to be. This year, they scrapped that. "I was a big proponent of removing it because it gave people an excuse to not be as bought in," Prieto Black said. "We really just want people who are excited to be together and will actually lean into meeting new people and integrating themselves into the new community, so, often that is in alignment with doing embarrassing things."

Both Edon and Aeris have refined their traditions beyond pledging, often layering in new structures or making subtle linguistic shifts to reflect their changing identities. Aeris, for instance, created a leadership role dedicated to Risk, ensuring that pledging remains within clear boundaries. Instead of the conventional "bigs and littles," new Edon members refer to upperclassmen as "Uncles and Aunties," and upperclassmen refer to pledges as "Predons"—a minor but intentional reframing.

Edon also imitates Yale's secret society culture, incorporating 45-minute "bios," during which new members recount their life stories to their Dev class. The group also meets every Thursday, a subtle

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homage to the societies' long-standing traditions. This selective borrowing—adapting rituals from other social groups to create something new—is possible only when an organization operates without fixed boundaries.

Financial independence has also reshaped their priorities. Without national oversight, these groups decide how to allocate dues and which organizations to support through philanthropy. Aeris allows members to vote on which organizations to fundraise for—last year, they chose The Diaper Bank of Connecticut. Edon avoids formal fundraisers or ticketed events, prioritizing accessibility in their social gatherings, and has Predons volunteer at local soup kitchens as part of their Dev tasks.

Aeris has worked to expand financial aid—something Panhellenic organizations are not permitted to provide. "Each semester since disaffiliation, we've seen more applications for aid—an encouraging sign that our membership is becoming more socioeconomically diverse and that members feel comfortable asking for assistance," said Robertson.

Aeris takes a less extended approach, structuring its recruitment over a week, similar to the Panhellenic rush. But unlike the sorority recruitment—initially structured as three rounds of six, fifteen, and thirty minutes—Aeris revised its process after its first year. Now, the second round consists of two 30-minute coffee chats, each with a pair of Aeris members and a PNM. They also covered the cost of

coffee for everyone rushing.

This switch made a difference. "Their intention behind actually sitting down to get to know the girls, [and taking] so much time out of their days… They weren't doing just one coffee; they were doing multiple," said Skye Wu '28, an Aeris pledge. "I think that really says something about the girls that were willing to sit down for hours and just simply get to know the people."

From the start, Fence, Edon, and Aeris have kicked off their rush processes with launch parties—an introduction for PNMs to get a feel for the organization. After all, at their core, these groups are meant for partiers.

What sets these parties apart is that women are either co-hosts or the ones hosting them. "I don't think Edon's immune to [the common issues with Greek life], just because there are women and queer people in this space," said Makda Assefa '26, a former Rush chair and DEI chair. "But something I appreciated about Edon was that women weren't just guests at the party; they were the hosts. I still go to frat parties, but I felt very empowered being able to say, 'This is partially my party.'"

Manriquez highlighted the impact of having a female-led space for hosting parties. As a Communication and Consent Educator (CCE), she works to foster a healthier social and sexual climate on campus. "I go to an Aeris party, and many people tell me, 'Oh my god, I feel so much [calmer],' or 'I don't have a bunch of guys circling me, staring at me.' Of course, we don't throw perfect parties, and we still have room for improvement, and we don't host that often." She added that while she enjoys attending male-hosted parties as well, the inclusion of a female-hosted space simply "diversifies options."

The reality is that while these groups offer more options, the pool of party spaces at Yale remains small. Party culture here is an afterthought, not a foundation. It's not that serious; the biggest selling point for Jang to join Fence was "that people actually get down at [Fence] parties."

He also just loves the music. "Like there's a lot of gay music. A lot of early 2000 songs and they play the new Lady Gaga song a lot," he said.

Yet, despite the small presence of party culture at Yale, Manriquez still poured much of her energy into Aeris. "Aeris is my baby," she repeated throughout our conversation.

As a "founding mother," she had to negotiate with Phi Pi's national leadership to allow the group to disaffiliate and secure a two-thirds majority vote from members. She filed the 501(c)(7) paperwork—using the same accountant as LEO—and helped draft the organization's 25-page bylaws. A third of the membership was directly involved in the leadership board.

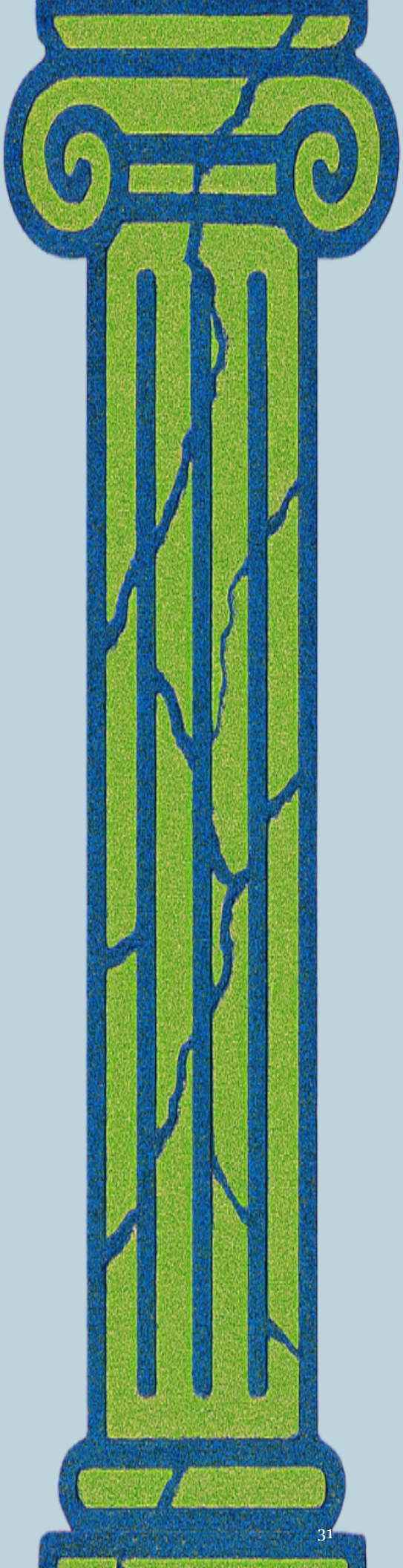
"Some people criticized us, saying, 'Oh, they're just renaming themselves.' I think that's incorrect. We're handling the budget all on our own," Manriquez said. "We're handling insurance and risk on our own. We're running literally everything by ourselves." She said that now that they do not have a larger organization to guide them, the Executive Board has had to put in a lot more work.

At the same time, not having a national organization can deter PNMs from rushing. An anonymous freshman who made it to the last round of Kappa Alpha Theta, Alpha Phi, and Aeris ultimately chose Theta because "national organizations have better infrastructure and support systems." She continued to explain that the national organization offers scholarships and access to networking through alumni or other Thetas at other schools.

Despite not having a national organization, the groups work hard to create the same structural support, aiming to provide the same level of resources and guidance. The work that goes into these organizations is immense, yet it rarely makes it onto a résumé. But for people like Manriquez, the effort to remake these institutions has always been about something else. Prieto Black, who had formative experiences pledging, stepped into leadership roles for the same reason. It's simple: These are people who thrive on community, who relish meeting new people, and who want to ensure that future classes can experience the same sense of belonging—and the same fun—that they once did.

"I wanted to help shape it into all the potential it had—to fulfill it, to realize its truest form, to reach what the founding mothers had envisioned," said Prieto Black.

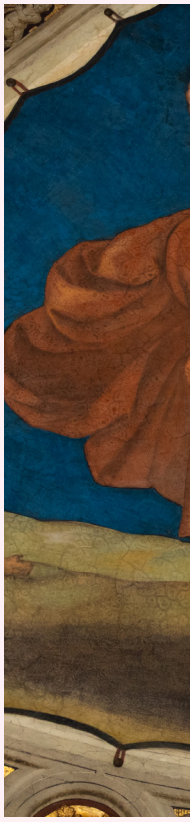
While starting from a small foundation presents logistical challenges, it also offers members a rare freedom—the power to shape the organization entirely in their vision.

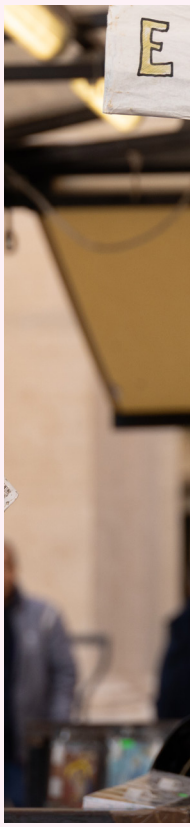


Sanctity and Souvenirs: A Study in Contrasts at the Vatican

BY RORY SCHOENBERGER







Vatican City, the spiritual heart of the Roman Catholic Church, is revered as one of the holiest places on earth. Yet, upon entering its thousand-year-old walls, rampant tourism and consumerism seem to dilute the sense of spirituality the city is designed to evoke. It begs the question: How can spaces remain sacred in an increasingly capitalistic and consumerist society?

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